



▲ **The Kothavalasa–Kirandul line** passes through many scenic valleys and tunnels in the Eastern Ghats.

Dandakaranya, a sparsely populated, dense forest in the heart of central India, finds a place in Hindu mythology as the home of Rama, the main protagonist of the epic *Ramayana*, during his 14-year exile. Extending to nearly 92,000 sq km and into parts of Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Odisha, and Chhattisgarh, the area became recognized for its rich resources in the late 19th century when reputed geologist PN Bose discovered iron ore in the hills of Bailadila.

The area had always been rich in minerals with extensive reserves of haematite, but the rugged terrain and inhospitable climate deterred even the most determined explorer seeking to exploit its wealth. Until the 1960